

The River Dragon's Long Sleep

The blossom mountains of Yamato rise in soft green folds above terraced rice fields and little villages strung with paper lanterns, where cherry trees drop their petals on the wind and red torii gates mark the quiet shrines. Mist drifts among the bamboo, the moon lays a silver path on the river, and the hills are full of gentle spirits: a riddling fox, shy fireflies who light the lanterns, a jolly trickster tanuki, stone guardian dogs, and a great old river dragon who brings the rains. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is patient, thinks things through, and is kind to every living thing. The grandest deeds are done with wisdom and courage and a gentle heart, and even a fearsome guardian, met with a calm and friendly word, often turns out kinder than it looks.



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Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.

Before you begin

All through the long, dry summer the rains had not come. The Silver River, which fed every terraced field in the valley, sank lower week by week, until the young rice stood pale and thirsty and the elders watched the cloudless sky with worried faces.

For high on the mountain, in a deep bend of the river, slept the Gentle River Dragon, whose slow stirring had brought the rains since before anyone could remember. This year he had slept far too long, and no one knew how to wake him.

Granny Yuki the Tale-Keeper called the two of you to her side. "You have clever heads and kind hearts," she said, "and that is worth more up the mountain than any strength. Will you climb over the pass and wake him, gently, before the harvest fails?"

Into your hands she pressed three gifts: a little bronze bell with a clear, soft ring, a ball of bright red thread, and a sweet rice cake wrapped in a leaf. "Remember," she said, "up there we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being wise, brave, and kind."

What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Wisdom, Courage, or Kindness?

Stop 1: The Guardian Gate

The path climbed steeply through the cedars until it reached the Red Torii Gate, tall and vermilion against the green of the mountain. On either side crouched a great stone lion-dog, so still you might have walked straight past them. Then, as you drew near, the stone seemed to soften: they blinked, they stretched, and they turned their carved heads to look at you.

"None may pass," the Guardian Lion-Dogs rumbled together, "until you answer our riddle." Their voices were deep as a temple drum, and for a moment your heart beat quick. But there was no cruelty in their eyes, only a fair and patient sort of watchfulness. They would have liked a clever answer, and they would not have minded a brave, thoughtful guess.

Will you listen closely and puzzle it out together? Kon the Fox is somewhere near the bamboo, and he loves to whisper a hint. What do you try?

When your answer came, the Guardian Lion-Dogs nodded slowly and settled back onto their pedestals. "Well thought," they said, and a low, pleased rumble followed you as the great gate swung open and let you through.

Stop 2: The Moonlit Bridge

Beyond the gate the daylight faded, and a round silver moon rose over the river. There the path met an old arched bridge of dark wood, beautiful and a little frightening, for it swayed and groaned whenever the wind pushed at it. The water ran fast and black far below.

You understood, almost at once, what the bridge asked of you. It held firm only for those who crossed it slowly and calmly, together: no rushing, no fear-driven scramble, just one steady step after another, with a brave and quiet heart.

How will you cross? Will you go gently, side by side, breathing slow? You might tie the red thread between you so that you stay together all the way. What is your plan?

By crossing slowly and calmly, hand in hand, you kept the bridge steady beneath your feet. It carried you the whole long arc above the water, and set you down at last on the far bank, safe in the drifting mist.

Stop 3: The Sleeping Dragon

And there, at last, lay the great River Dragon. He was curled along a deep, misty bend of the river, his long body vast as a green hill, his breath rising and falling slow as the tide. He had slept so very long that mist had gathered on his scales and reeds had grown between his claws. He looked, for a moment, like the end of the adventure.

But this was never a fight, and could never be one. You could no more battle such a creature than battle the mountain itself, and you would not have wished to. He was not fierce. He was gentle, and, you slowly understood, he was lonely, for no one had climbed all this way to sit with him in a very long time.

This calls for a calm and careful kindness. You carry a little bell that rings soft and clear, the kind of sound that wakes a friend without a fright. You could ring it gently and sing him a quiet song. What do you do?

When you rang the little bell and sang, soft and low, the great dragon's sleepy eyes drifted open, deep and dark and kind. "Someone came," he murmured, as though he could scarcely believe it. "Someone came to wake me kindly, and not with shouting." And he smiled, slow as sunrise.

The Rains Return

The River Dragon uncurled and rose, grand and unhurried, into the moonlit sky. He wound above the valley like a long blue ribbon, and everywhere his shadow passed, a soft, warm rain began to fall, the first rain of the whole long summer.

The Silver River swelled and brimmed and shone. Far below, the thirsty rice fields drank deep and turned, almost as you watched, a glad and living green. And the dragon was lonely no longer, for now he had two friends who would climb the mountain to see him again.

As the clouds thinned, Amaterasu the Sun-Kami broke through with a warm gold light and smiled down upon you. You had done it, and you had done it together: with your wisdom, with your courage, and above all with your kindness. Well done, heroes of the Blossom Mountains.

The Story in Pictures



Two heroes thinking before a tall red torii gate guarded by two friendly stone lion-dogs with kind faces, blossom and moonlight around.



Two heroes crossing a gracefully arched wooden bridge over a wide river silver in the moonlight, stepping gently together.



Two heroes gently ringing a little bell beside a great gentle river dragon curled asleep among misty water, beginning to stir.



A great gentle river dragon awake and rising into a dawn sky as soft rain falls, the river
brimming and green rice fields drinking, two heroes cheering below.

My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

I am a hero of

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can

What I carry

Notes

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.

Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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